At one level, today's uncertainties induce greater caution about international exposure, whether we consider it from the perspective of implementing strategy or mitigating vulnerabilities. India happens to have concerns on both scores. But beyond a point, that cannot be fully hedged against, since the very nature of our existence now is very globalized. For each nation, especially the major ones, a set of answers has to be found that optimize risks and benefits.

This has led to a revival of interest in strategic autonomy, now redefined as ensuring national capabilities in core and sensitive areas. This process of adjusting towards a different basis of global interaction has naturally generated its own outlook. In our own domestic discourse, we know this as *atmanirbhar* Bharat, that is, self-reliant India. The digital domain has seen its own variation of similar compulsions. Events in 2020 sharpened awareness in India of an exposure that had been built up over decades. The clean app approach and the embrace of concepts like 'trusted providers' and 'trusted geographies' are a resulting outcome.

It is a paradox in many ways that while we speak of the advancements of technology and promise of science, world politics is actually moving 'back to the future'. Some of this arises from the expectations placed on globalization proving to be over-optimistic. This is not to suggest that the underlying economic interdependence is not well-founded. But widening differences among and within societies and creation of new global equations have meant that counter forces of globalization have been set into motion. Once challenges began to be articulated, the globalization model was not easy to defend precisely because its benefits were so heavily skewed.

Political expressions of globalization have also created their own backlash. When self-appointed custodians of correctness sit in judgement over democratically elected representatives, they cannot expect to be unchallenged, especially when they have such visible stakes in the preferred outcomes. To add to that, some countries are advancing aspects of their own model as an example abroad. Cumulatively, this has led to a situation where political and social identities have resurfaced strongly, creating inherent tensions with the nature of economic flows. Because there are so many moving parts, these predicaments are not easy to resolve.

Consequently, different nations are struggling to find the right balance, though the reasons in each case may be different. Some seek to address